Origin

At approximately 10,000 BC, an earthquake occurred that divided a part of Australia. This land collapsed with parts of the Himalayas, and the mountains were formed. From there, the Ganga started to flow directly to the Bay of Bengal. Which deposited soil, creating a fertile land. In search of a livable land, first came the Mongoloids and Australoids. They started basic farming here. Then came the Arians from the France-German border, who were warriors and shepherds with better knowledge of farming and the state system. People in this land were 'Arianized'. They were known as Maurja and named this land Pundravardan.

Janapada

According to Vedic literature, the ancient janapadas were the non-Aryans who inhabited this area much before the Aryans came to this area.

- Pundra
- Varendra
- Vanga
- Vangal
- Samatata
- Harikela
- Gaud

Situation of the subcontinent after the collapse of Guptas

Due to weak succession, invasions by external threats, economic challenges, fragmentation of power, and social & cultural changes, the Gupta dynasty declined. After the declination, Banga and Gaur—two different kingdoms emerged. But the Banga kingdom was destroyed later on, which ensured the rise of Gaur. In the meantime, Sasanka was extending his political territory. He held his own emperor against powerful combined enemies until his death.

Sasanka, the first independent king of Bengal

Sasanka is the first known king of Bengal. He was a Sanskreet speaking subject king of the Guptas. He started as a vassal of the Maukhary king. He was also a subordinate ruler under the later Guptas. Around 606 AD, he became the king of Guar, with his capital at Karnasubarna. He died between 616 - 637 AD.

Dark age (Matsya Nyaya)

The era after the death of Sasanka until the Pala imperial dynasty is considered the dark age, or matsya nyaya. This era is considered a dark age because there was no strong succession or

ruler in this era to rule and protect this land. Many invasions and wars were seen at that time. This land was in a state of political disintegration and passed through many invasions till the Pala dynasty in the eighth century.

The Pala Dynasty

To end the problems of the dark age, Gopal was selected as the new king of this land, thus beginning the Pala dynasty. Though it is said that people made Gopal the king, the selection must have been made by a group of chieftains, which was subsequently endorsed by the general people. Gopal's main achievement was the establishment of durable peace in Bengal by bringing his turbulent chiefs under his control. He unified Gaur, Varendra, Banga, and Magadha into one kingdom. After Gopal's death, his son, Dharmapal succeeded the throne and took Pala rule to imperial glory. His empire did not suffer much diminution during the rest of his life, and he spent his final days in peace. Dharmapal was succeeded by his son, Devapal, under whom the Pala dynasty reached the zenith of its glory.

The Pala dynasty was known for its religious tolerance. Even though they were Buddhists, people of other religions also had the chance to practice their religion. During their time, the caste system was eradicated from society. The Pala dynasty witnessed a flourish of literature in various languages, including Sanskreet and Bengali. Most people were farmers during this era.

Later, although Mahipal I resurrected the already declining dynasty, Mahipal II's rule continued the decline. He was an oppressive ruler and threw his brothers into prison for power. The Pala dynasty lasted for around 400 years.

The Kaibarta rebellion

Soon there was a well-organized rebellion by a confederation of lower castes led by Divya. Divya and the Kaibartas were rated low, associated with boatmen, fishermen, or forest-settlers, hunters, and raiders. As the oppression of Pala king Mahipal II began and the power of the Pala dynasty weakened, the Kaibartas, led by Divya, rebelled. They defeated Mahipal II and established a dynasty for half a century.

The Sena Dynasty

After the end of the Pala dynasty, came the Sena dynasty. This dynasty started with Samanta Sena as their first ruler. The Sena rulers, as they were Hindus, brought back the caste system in Bengal. They also constructed many temples and promoted agriculture and trading. During the Sena dynasty, the culture and literature of Bengal flourished.

The Sena dynasty faced invasions from external forces, primarily the Delhi Sultanate. During the rule of Lakshmana Sena, the Delhi Sultanate, led by various rulers, aimed to expand its territory and influence in the Indian subcontinent. The sultans launched multiple military campaigns against Bengal, gradually weakening the Sena dynasty's control over the region. This dynasty lasted for over a hundred years.

Serial No.	Pala Dynasty	Sena Dynasty
1	No caste system	Reintroduced caste system
2	Showed religious tolerance	Showed religious intolerance
3	Hindu Buddhist amity was achieved	Rivalry between Hindu Buddhist
4	Developed architectural art and practiced sculptural art	Sanskrit literature and sculptural art reached watermark

Turkish Invasion (Muslim Dynasty)

Delhi Sultanate

- Ikhtiar Uddin Muhammad Bin Bakhtiar Khilji
- Firoz Shah

Ikhtiar Uddin Muhammad Bin Bakhtiar Khilji was a Turkish general who wanted to expand the territories under the Muslim control of the Delhi Sultanate. He came to Bengal to see the rich opportunities of trading and business. At that time, internal conflicts and the succession of weak rulers in the Sena dynasty were evident. Bakhtiar Khilji invaded and expelled the last Sena king, Lakshmana Sena. Later, while he was on a quest to invade Tibet, Bakhtiar was assassinated.

Bengal was initially ruled by governors appointed by the Delhi Sultanate. Over time, the governors and their descendants integrated into the local society and adopted aspects of Bengali culture.

The Sultanates introduced Islam to Bengal, leading to the conversion of a significant portion of the population to Islam. This brought change to the religious practices, social norms and laws.

The rulers also encouraged trade and commerce in Bengal, which led to the growth of urban centers and the establishment of markets. Bengal became an important trading hub, attracting merchants from different parts of Asia. The Turkish rulers introduced new agricultural practices and irrigation systems, which resulted in increased agricultural productivity. The adoption of advanced agricultural techniques contributed to economic growth and stability.

The Bengal culture and language during that time integrated with the Turkish, Persian culture, effects of which can still be seen now on some old architectures, language, songs. Turkish influence contributed to the development of new musical styles such as ghazal. Literature flourished during that time.

FIroz Shah conquered Sonargaon and Mymensingh. He helped Hajrat Shah Jalal to conquer Sylhet. Later, Iliyas Shah came and brought the whole Bengal under his control.

However, there were also instances of local resistance and uprisings against Turkish rule.

Bengal Sultanate (Independent Sultanate)

- *Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah*
- *Ilyas Shah*
- *Sikandar Shah*
- Sher Shah Suri

Sometime later, Bengal governor, Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah declared independence from the Delhi Sultanate, with Lakhnauti being the capital. Sikanda Shah expanded the territories of the Bengal Sultanate through military campaigns. Sher Shah Suri created Grand Trunk Road. He was a strong emperor. Humayun couldn't conquer it because of Sher Shah Suri.

In this era, Sufi saints and mystics played a crucial role in spreading Islam and shaping the religious and cultural practices of the people.

Architectural marvels, including mosques, tombs and palaces were constructed in various parts of Bengal.

Trade and commerce flourished, aided by Bengal's strategic location and its access to river networks and the Bay of Bengal. Bengal was a major hub for various regions. The production of textiles, particularly muslin and silk, was a magnificent industry. Bengal's fine muslin fabrics were highly sought after in international markets.

Bara Bhuiyans

- Isa Khan
- Musa Khan
- Masum Khan
- Kandarpa Narayan
- Raja Pratap Aditya
- Kedar Rai
- Daud Khan
- Uthman Khan

The bara bhuiyans were the independent landlords of the Bhati region. They were the former governors of Bengal Sultanate. They denied paying taxes to the Mughal Empire and that's why

the Mughal Empire tried to capture Bengal. Mughal Emperor Akbar appointed Maan Singh, who defeated Daud Khan and Uthman Khan and killed Kedar Rai. Later, Mughal Emperor Jahangir appointed Islam Khan Chishti, who killed Uthman Khan.

Mughal Dynasty (Subadars under the Delhi Mughal)

- Babur (invaded Delhi Sultanate)
- Humayun (was defeated by Sher Shah Suri)
- Akbar (invaded Bengal)
- Jahangir
- Shah Jahan
- Aurangazeb

Descendent of Timur and Genghis Khan, Babur (first Mughal emperor) led an army into northern India and defeated the Delhi Sultanate at the Battle of Panipat. This marked the beginning of Mughal rule in India.

Babur's son, Humayun, continued to expand the empire's territories. During the reign of Humayun, an Afghan ruler, Sher Shah Suri attacked and Humayun lost a few territories to him and fled to Persia. But he returned to India later. Humayun was known for his patronage to arts, literature and culture. He established a grand court that attracted renowned artists, poets and scholars, contributing to the development of a refined cultural environment. Humayun promoted trade and commerce within the empire and encouraged the growth of trade routes.

As the Bengal sultanate was weakened by internal conflicts and external invasions, the Mughals found an opportunity to expand their empire. Mughal emperor Akbar's force defeated the last independent Sultan of Bengal and Akbar appointed Mughal governors known as Subadars to administer Bengal. His rule marked a period of political stability, territorial expansion, religious tolerance, cultural innovation and administrative reforms.

However, the complete annexation of Bengal into the Mughal Empire happened during the reign of Shah Jahan. His reign is often referred to as the "Golden Age of the Mughal Empire". He built the Taj Mahal and was known for his patronage of the arts and architecture. The Mughal court under his rule saw a flourishing of art and culture.

After Shah Jahan, came his son, Aurangazeb. Aurangazeb was a strict ruler who expanded the Mughal Empire to its greatest extent. But after his death, the Mughal Empire started to decline.

Independent Bengal Subadar (Nawab)

- Murshid Quli Khan
- Sarfaraz Khan
- Alivardi Khan

The transition from the Delhi Subadar to the Independent Subadar of Bengal occurred during the decline of the Mughal Empire. When the Mughal Empire was experiencing a period of

political instability, economic decline and territorial fragmentation, subadars of Bengal started asserting more autonomy and independent rule and gradually detached themselves from the authority of the Mughal Emperor.

One prominent figure during this period was Murshid Quli Khan, who was appointed as a subadar of Bengal by Aurangazeb. He laid the foundation for an independent administration. He tried to conserve Bengal's revenue and prevent its diversion. He founded the zamindari system. Bengal prospered economically during his reign. Trading and textile, along with farming, was the main key for the economy during this period.

Later, Sarfaraz Khan succeeded to the throne. But his reign came to an end when Alivardi Khan defeated and killed him, and as a triumphant Alivardi ascended the throne of Bengal. But his reign was full of invasions by the Marathas and internal and family conflict

British East India Company (1757 - 1857)

Battle of Palassey (End of independent Bengal Subadar or Nawab)

After his death, Alivardi's grandson Siraj-ud-Daula, the last independent Bengal subadar or Nawab, ascended the throne. During his reign, there were internal conflicts, political rivalries and British interference in Bengal's affair. The British East India Company was looking for ways to spread their influence and control over Bengal's trade. They had supporters like Jagath Seth, Ghasheti Begum, Mir Jafar, who were close to Siraj-ud-Daula. Jagath Seth was a merchant whose business and trading had a deep connection with the British East India Company.

British East India Company, led by Lord Robert Clive and formed alliances with nobles close to Nawab, conflicted against Siraj-ud-Daula. Mir Jafar's betrayal and the British's superior military tactics and firepower defeated the Nawab and Mir Jafar was declared as the new ruler.

Mir Jafar was basically a British puppet ruling Bengal. The British East India Company gained significant control over Bengal's trading region.

Battle of Buxar (1764)

Later, tensions between the British East India Company and Mughal Emperor and Nawabs of Bengal and Awadh increased, which led to the battle of Buxar. Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II, Bengal Nawab Mir Qasim and Awadh Nawab Shuja-ud-Daula formed an alliance and fought against the British East India Company but the allied force suffered a heavy loss. The Emperor and Nawabs signed a peace treaty with the British East India Company and the Company was granted Diwani rights. Which meant that, the British East India Company could collect the revenue of Bengal.

Despite the loss of the Mughal Emperor to the British East India Company, tshe company didn't take over the whole India; rather, they took the Diwani rights of Bengal from Shah Alam II because they were merchants and only needed money. So, they took the right to collect the taxes that helped them run their business and send the extras to their country. Land tax was increased which resulted in a shortfall in crops and famine in 1770. To overhaul the management of the East India Company's rule in India the Parliament of Great Britain passed the Regulating Act which created a new post called Governor General. Warren Hastings was the first Governor General, who implemented many economic reforms but they all failed.

Permanent Settlement Act (Sunset Law)

To make Bengal profitable, the British parliament sent Lord Cornwallis to Bengal. He implemented the Permanent Settlement Act. In this act, a land revenue system started, where some rich men were given a vast amount of lands, who were called as the zamindars or landlords. Farmers or peasants worked under them on their lands. A fixed amount of revenue was fixed and the landlords had to pay the revenue/taxes before the sunset and so, it was also called the sunset law. The landlords would lose their lands if they failed to pay taxes by time. These high taxes would bring poverty to the farmers. From here came the idea of owning lands and the landlords also had the right to protect their land.

But later, Lord Cornwallis brought the British Judiciary system to Bengal. With this the land landlords were left with one job, collecting high taxes fixed by the British.

But the taxes were so high that most landlords failed to meet the limit and lost their lands, which were later divided into smaller lands and auctioned (they were auctioned because the British didn't have the right to own lands of Bengal). Most Banyas, who were high class Hindu merchants, bought these lands. They lived in Calcutta and to collect revenues for the farmers, they rented people from local areas of Bengal. The farmers became agricultural laborers. These tax collectors soon became rich enough so they migrated to Calcutta and hired more people under them to collect those revenues. This class between the landlords and the peasant farmers were called middle class people (from here came the idea of middle class). The rich people (mostly merchants) in Calcutta sent their children to English missionary schools which later led to the Bengal renaissance.

Early reforms and repercussions

Education Act of 1835: The education act of 1835, also known as the Macaukay's Minute on Education, was a significant piece of legislation during British colonial rule in India. The main objective was to spread Western education in India and create a class who are loyal to the British. They promoted English education and established English schools. While this introduced modern education to India, it also resulted in the erosion of traditional knowledge systems and the privileging of Western knowledge and values.

Bengal Renaissance: As education spread among the people of India, the young generation became aware about all the social injustice and superstitions that were happening around them.

Prominent people like Raja Ram Mohon Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Rabindranath Tagore, Derozario came front and brought many social reforms, including abolition of Satidaho, legalization of widow marriage, practice of literature and art, modernization of education, nationalism and political awakening etc. They became familiar with nationalism, socialism and other aspects of politics.

Young Bengal Movement: The Young Bengal Movement was a significant intellectual and social reform movement that emerged in the early 19th century in Bengal, India. It was led by a group of young, educated Bengali intellectuals who sought to challenge traditional social norms, religious orthodoxy, and British colonialism. The movement had a profound impact on the cultural, literary, and political landscape of Bengal during that time. The Young Bengal Movement was characterized by its emphasis on rationality, critical thinking, and social reform. The members of this movement were influenced by Western Enlightenment ideals and were inspired by the liberal and progressive ideas of thinkers. They sought to combine the best of Indian and Western knowledge and values to create a more enlightened and just society. The movement advocated for the abolition of social evils such as satidaho, child marriage, and caste discrimination. It promoted education for women, the spread of scientific knowledge, and the freedom of expression. The Young Bengal intellectuals used literature, journalism, and public debates to challenge prevailing orthodoxies and to promote their ideas. The Young Bengal Movement faced opposition from conservative elements of society, including orthodox religious leaders and British colonial authorities. The movement's progressive ideas and challenges to traditional norms were seen as a threat to established social structures and colonial control.

Fakir-Sannyasi Revolt (The first peasant revolt against the British)

The Fakir-Sannyasi revolt, led by Fakir Majnu Shah and Bhabani Pathak, was a result of high revenue pressure and torture on the farmers, ban on beggings and religious sentiments. The Fakirs and Sannyasis lived on the foods and supplies that were provided by the farmers. But as the British implemented high tax on the farmers, they were not able to provide the fakirs and sannyasis anymore; also the British didn't allow any form of begging. Which led the fakir-sannyasis to unite with farmers and revolt against the British. The rebels' main targets were the landlords and the company officials. To tackle the rebels, the British East India Company used both military and political power. After some time, the battle gradually stopped.

Forty Forts (Basher Kella by Titumir)

This revolt was led by Syed Mir Nasir Ali, also popularly known as Titumir. It was a response to the oppressive policies of the British colonial administration and the local landlords. This rebellion was fueled by the torture on the peasant farmers. Titumir encouraged farmers not to pay revenues to the landlords. Several bamboo forts were made throughout Bengal to provide centers of resistance and a safe place for the rebels. The rebels created their own government. These acts soon gained Titumir lots of followers. They carried out guerilla attacks, ambushed the oppressors and successfully defended their forts against the landlords. As the landlords kept suffering, they complained to the British East India Company. To provide support, the British East India Company force stepped in and soon the revolt was stopped.

Bengal Indigo Revolt

Bengal farmers were forced to cultivate indigo (neel) instead of food crops as the British needed products made of indigo. Indigo-crops make the lands infertile which makes growing food-crops difficult for farmers, which resulted in food shortage and famine in Bengal. Although the farmers didn't want to cultivate indigo, they were forced to with cruel punishments and high taxes. This situation eventually led the farmers to revolt against the British as they had no food.

Faraizi Movement

Faraizi movement is a socio-religious movement that took place in Bengal, which was led by Haji Shariatullah Mahsin, a prominent Islamic preacher and reformer. He came back from his pilgrimage and saw the impure form of Islam among the muslims of Bengal, with lots of superstitions, as most of the muslims were actually converted low class hindus. To purify Islam in Bengal, he created a platform for the peasant farmers where he could teach them more about their religion. Soon, this platform led to revolt.

After Haji Shariatullah's death, his son took over the revolt as a leader and started with a new pace. But soon the revolt was interrupted by the British soldiers.

Santhal Rebellion

The Santhal Rebellion was a significant uprising of the Santhal indigenous people against British colonial rule in India. The Santhals, an indigenous community, faced exploitation, land alienation, and oppressive practices due to the introduction of the land settlement system. The rebellion was led by brothers Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu and spread rapidly across the region. The Santhals demonstrated courage and resilience, despite facing heavy casualties. The rebellion inspired other indigenous communities to challenge British authority and fight for their rights.

Sepoy Mutiny (First Indian War of Independence, 1857)

Sepoy Mutiny is considered as the first war of independence against British rule which started in 1857 and lasted for a year. There are several reasons behind this revolt. Many Bengali were working as sepoys or soldiers in the British East India Company force. But discrimination was seen in the army, as the Bengal sepoys didn't get as much wages as the British and they were hardly promoted to upper ranks. So the sepoys were discontent with their treatment, which was fueled by the rumor that they had to use new rifles with cartridges that were made from animal fat, which offended the religious sector of Hindu and Muslim soldiers. The soldiers were also discontent with how the rulers behaved towards the commoners. All these incidents finally led to the rebellion.

On May 10, 1857, when the soldiers refused to use the new rifles, they were court-martialed. This act of defiance triggered a widespread rebellion among the sepoys. This rebellion quickly spread throughout India. The rebels targeted British military and administrative centers and loyal

India landlords who supported the British. Later the rebellion was brutally suppressed by the British and it gradually lost momentum. Mughal Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar was captured and then exiled in Rangoon.

British Crown Rule (1857-1947)

Because of the sepoy mutiny and famine, which was caused because of forced indigo cultivation, the British government ruled out the British East India Company and directly started ruling Bengal. Thus began the British crown rule in Bengal. The governance structure was reorganized, with the Viceroy of India appointed as the representative of the British monarch and the highest-ranking official in India and a legislative council was formed. India was divided into several provinces with Bengal, Madraj and Bombay presidency.

The British government realized that there was no platform for Indians to communicate to them. To solve this issue, they brought out representatives from Indians and formed the Indian National Congress (1885). Hindu Landlords, who were rich, joined the political party. This party was dominated by the bhadralok class.

Sir Syed Ahmed Khan advised muslims not to join politics. Because they at first didn't accept the English. The first generation of Indian politicians were satisfied but soon emerged new Indian politicians who were educated and familiar with European politics such as nationalism, socialism. As they were educated, they were ambitious and realized how the British treated the people of color. Soon they moved from Calcutta to Rural areas of Bengal among the peasant farmers to gather mass support.

Hunter Commission (by Sir William Hunter)

Hunter commission, named after the chairman Sir William Hunter, was formed to review the primary and higher education system in India. It was the first education commission in modern India to review the state of education since and recommend necessary measures for further progress. They helped spread education across India.

Mohammedan Literary Society (by Nawab Abdul Latif)

The Mohammedan Literary Society, founded by Nawab Abdul Lateef in 1863, was established to educate Muslims in western learning through English. The society held monthly meetings in Urdu, Persian, Arabic, and English languages, with discussions on subjects such as science, arts, and living issues. Lateef aimed to restore self-confidence among Muslims and initiate a new phase of social development by introducing modern education and intellectual discussions. The society became a meeting-place of distinguished scholars and learned persons, with notable figures. Nawab Abdul Lateef drew attention to fundamental issues confronting Muslims and spreading higher education among Muslims.

Aligarh Movement (by Sir Syed Ahmed Khan)

After the Sepoy Mutiny, the Muslims were recognized as backward sections as the majority were illiterate and hopelessly facing failures in every walk of life. They were deprived of their basic rights and were neglected and victimized. Sir Syed Ahmad Khan compelled the Muslim society to get themselves acquainted with modern and western education. He believed that the cure of every problem of Muslims was modern education, the only key to political and economic progress. Therefore, he commenced many educational programs to uplift the deprived Muslims. He took some concrete steps for education plans and reforms by the Aligarh Movement. The main objectives of this movement were to encourage mutual understanding between the British government and the Indian Muslims, encourage Muslims towards Education, make the Muslims realize that their betterment lies to stay away from political agitation, instill intellectual aspects in Indian Muslims.

First Partition of Bengal (1905)

In 1905, Lord Curzon, the Viceroy of India proposed the idea of parting Bengal as Bengal was a big land for them to rule. The Eastern province of Bengal would be formed with East Bengal and Assam as a Muslim majority land. The Western province of Bengal would be formed with West Bengal, Bihar and Orissa as a Hindu majority land. On one hand, Congress was against the idea and on the other hand, the muslims of Bengal supported the idea.

Swadeshi Movement

The Hindus were not happy with the idea of Bengal partition for several reasons. They treated this land as Goddess and parting the land would mean disrespecting their religion. Lawyers (if Bengal parted, they would lose clients), businessmen (business based in Calcutta would lose clients of other parts of Bengal), landlords (looking over their lands in rural areas of other part of Bengal would be hard from Calcutta), journalists (they would lose readers from other part) – four classes of people disagreed with the idea of partition of Bengal. This led to the Swadeshi Movement of Bengal. The rebels demanded annulment of partition, establishment of self rule, boycott British goods, engagement in civil disobedience and even commit political assassinations.

In the meantime, prominent Muslim leaders in Dhaka felt the need to form a political party to encounter the anti-partition revolt with the objectives of safeguarding the interests of the Indian Muslims, which led to the establishment of All India Muslim League. Their objectives were to look after the interests of the Muslims.

Morley-Minto Act (1909)

The Morley-Minto Reforms marked the beginning of representative government in India, aiming to establish a separate electorate for Muslims. [1]Through this act, the number of members of the Legislative Council at the Center was increased from 16 to 60. [2]During this time, India was divided into 3 provinces: Bengal, Madras and Bombay. [3]The Act also introduced separate

electorates for Muslims, including an Indian on the central and provincial councils and the Secretary of State's council. [4]Cental government had more powers than Provincial government. [5]Members were permitted to discuss budget, suggest amendments and vote.

Although the Muslim League welcomed these reforms and offered cooperation, the Indian National Congress partly agreed, while the extremists from Congress disagreed with the reforms.

Annulment of the Partition (1911)

Due to the Swadeshi Revolt, the British government discarded the plan of Bengal partition. But at the same time, they moved the capital of India from Calcutta to Delhi. Although the Bengali Hindus were satisfied with this annulment of partition, they were upset about Calcutta losing the status of the Indian capital. But it created resentment among the Muslims in general and they became convinced that the interests of the Muslims were not safe in the hands of the Congress. Because of this annulment, Hindu-Muslim communal tension was created which led to the two fronts of anti-colonial nationalist politics – Hindu nationalism and Muslim nationalism.

Rowlatt Act

During the first world war, the British implemented the Rowlatt Act which restricted the people from gathering in a place, ultimately restricting the judicial involvement of Indians. This act granted immense power to the police, as they could arrest anyone without any warrant, violating the rights of civilians.

This Rowlatt Act led to the infamous Jallianwala Bagh massacre. During a festival in a park, when native people gathered for celebration, in the name of implementing the Rowlatt Act, the British army murdered all the people that were participating there in a crossfire. This incident caused the British government to rethink their approach, the Indians to lose their faith in the British government and sparked Satyagraha.

Non-cooperation movement / Home Rule movement & Khilafat movement

During the first world war, the dismemberment of the Ottoman Empire by the British angered Muslims which led to the Khilafat movement. This time, Gandhi supported the movement so that he could enlist Muslim supporters for the Congress. In a Congress Session, Gandhi linked issues of Swaraj with the Khilafat demands and adopted the plan for Non-cooperation movement.

Gandhi asked for the non-cooperation movement without bloodshed and wanted to show the British that they were mature enough to call for a movement without any fight. Their main goal was to boycott all British and their products and establish national institutions. But soon, a fight broke out which led to the death of a police officer in Chauri Chaura. This incident caused Mahatma Gandhi to stop the movement.

Bengal Pact (by Chittaranjan Das, 1924)

Deshbandhu Chittaranjan Das realized the unity of Hindu-Muslims of Bengal and called for a pact to unify them and resolve their differences. He, along with some prominent leaders proposed a pact which is known as the Bengal Pact – [1]No music near muslim holy places. [2]No legislation in slaughtering cows for food. [3]55% jobs for muslims in government appointments. [4]60% muslims can join local parliament.

Chittaranjan Das got whole hearted support of the Muslims of Bengal. But the pact was discarded in the provincial Congress conference, After the untimely death of Chittaranjan Das, this pact was discarded which dissatisfied the Muslims of Bengal.

Simon Commission

Indians wanted a reformation of the diarchy parliament, for which Simon Commission was established. They had the task to observe India for 10 years and after that, form a committee and create a constitution. But after 8 years, a committee of 7 was formed with all 7 members being British, saying that the Indians don't have what it takes to form a constitution, there will be no unity if Indians made constitutions.

This dissatisfied the Indians. Congress and Muhammad Ali Jinnah-led Muslim League opposed it. Congress leader Motilal Nehru formed a committee and made the Nehru report – [1]called for self-government, [2]strong central government, [3]equal rights and opportunities for all citizens.

This was also opposed by Mohammad Ali Zinnah-led Muslim League as the report did not adequately address the concerns of Muslim community. He created another committee and formed another report called the Zinnah report/14 points – [1]separate electorate for Muslims and other minorities, [2]establishment of Muslim-majority provinces.

Later, three conferences were held to review and combine all three reports (Simon, Nehru, Zinnah) and a new report was created.

Krishak Praja Party (KPP)

The nationalists failed to address the welfare of poor people of Bengal which resulted in the formation of Krishak Praja Party led by Sher-E-Bangla A. K. Fazlul Haq. This party was supported by many people of Bengal and the popularity of Muslim League declined.

The KPP demanded – [1]abolishment of the zamindari system, [2]reduction of land rate, [3]interest free loans for peasants, [4]creating irrigation facilities, digging canals, [5]free primary education.

In the election, KPP won 36 seats (33 from Bengal), Congress won 52 seats, Muslim League won 39 seats. Later, KPP formed a coalition government with the Muslim League and now they have more areas than Congress.

Lahore resolution (Two nations theory)

In a conference that was held in Lahore in 1940, the Lahore Resolution was proposed by Zinnah. In the resolution, he demanded for two nations, with one sovereign state for Muslims, which was supported by the Krishak Praja Party. This started the thinking of India-Pakistan division.

Cripps Mission (led by Sir Stafford Cripps)

The Cripps Mission was established by the British parliament in 1942 to address India's political crisis. Headed by Cabinet Minister Sir Stafford Cripps, the mission aimed to end Gandhi's Satyagraha movement and protect the British colonial empire. Cripps offered independence of India; a constituent assembly and more seats in Viceroy's executive council. Congress and the British Prime Minister opposed the mission's proposal. The plan ultimately failed, leading to the 'Quit India' movement.

Azad Hind Fauz (by Netaji Shubhash Chandra Bose)

Azad Hind Fauj was an Indian independence military force formed by Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose, who supported the Axis Powers during World War II. Subhash Bose secretly left Calcutta and went to Germany, where he formed the Provisional Independent Government of India with Germany's support. He established contact with Japan and was given the title of 'Netaji'. A conference in Bangkok was held to form a national army of India under Indian commanders. Subhash Chandra Bose declared the establishment of the Provisional Government of Independent India.

The Azad Hind Fauz advanced into India, but faced challenges from British forces, leading the Japanese to cancel the India campaign plan. Despite the challenges, the Azad Hind Fauj created a sense of nationalism among Indians and served as a great inspiration for the independence movement.

Bengal Famine (1943)

The Bengal famine of 1943 was a man-made famine created by the British government. Due to the fear of Japanese invasion, the British government confiscated boats that stopped trading, which led to the shortage of food crops. Shortage of food crops and widespread corruption finally resulted in the famine. However, the situation deteriorated due to natural disasters. The little amount of rice that was grown during that time was taken for the British army.

Wavell Plan and Simla Conference (1945)

Lord Wavell called a conference in Simla in 1945 to discuss the future of India with the British administration. In this conference, he proposed some ideas – [1]an all-Indian executive council to form interim government, [2]restriction on viceroy and commander-in chief position, [3]preservation of seats for caste Hindus and Muslims, [4]differences on the representation of Muslim community, [5]the Muslim League as the only Muslim representative, [6]the Congress as the representative of all communities.

Cabinet Mission (1946)

The Cabinet Mission arrived in India to negotiate a self-government with the party leaders. The mission proposed transferring the British power to a single Indian administration. They also proposed a three-tiered federation for India, maintaining national unity while allowing regional autonomy. The Indian National Congress and All India Muslim League primarily accepted the plan, but could not agree on an interim government. Later the Muslim League withdrew their support and the Cabinet Mission Plan failed.

Direct Action Day and the Great calcutta Killings

After the withdrawal of the Muslim League from the Cabinet Mission proposals, they announced a general strike which led to a widespread communal rioting between Muslims and Hindus. In this riot, an estimated 4000 people lost their lives. These incidents sowed the seeds for the eventual partition.

Proposal of United Bengal (by Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy)

Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, the Premier of the province of Bengal, formally launched the idea for a united Bengal. Sarat Chandra Bose proposed for a Sovereign Socialist Republic of Bengal. Most provincial Congress and Hindu leaders agreed to the proposal.

Partition and the Radcliffe Boundary Commission

In 1947, due to the postwar economic situation along with hostile Indian movements and communal riots, the British hastily decided to hand over the power to India. The Radcliffe Boundary Commission, founded by the British government, was responsible to demarcate the line between India and Pakistan within five weeks on the basis of religious demography. This partition created a mass migration and refugee crisis.

The Pakistan Period

Colonial Attacks on Language and Culture

Pakistan and India – the two countries were divided on the basis of religion. Pakistan had two wings – East Pakistan and West Pakistan. The two Paskitans were different from each other in terms of culture, language, economy etc. Political leaders believed that strong religious beliefs was the only way to unify these two different regions. Though East Pakistan people mostly shared the same language, culture, ethnic-buildup, tradition and economic activity, people of

West Pakistan had different cultures and backgrounds such as the Sikhs, the Pastuns, the Punjabis etc.

After the formation of Pakistan, at first came the issue of language. West Pakistani leaders realized that language was a political tool to solidify unity between East and West Pakistan and attempted to create a common language. Professor Ziauddin Ahmed proposed that Urdu, which was the language of the elite class of West, should be the state language of Pakistan. Only 3% of the total population of Pakistan spoke Urdu that time, where the majority of people in Pakistan spoke Bangla.

Tamaddun Majlish

On his only visit in Dhaka, Zinnah announced that Urdu should be the only language of Pakistan because it was more influenced by Arabic and represented Islam more than Bangla. This sparked a language movement in East Pakistan. Tamaddun Majlish, formed by influential leaders such as Dr. Mohammad Shahidullahj, played the pioneering role to protest against the attempt of making Urdu as the only state language of Pakistan. They took initiatives to form the first *Rashtrabhasha Sangram Parishad* (State Language Committee of Action). They issued a booklet titled *Pakistaner Rashtra Bhasha: Bangla na Urdu* which logically explained why Bangla should be the state language of Pakistan.

Movement for Bangla as the State Language

East Pakistan People, mostly students, responded to their call for language movement. Their participation in the movement and political programs was spontaneous and overwhelming. Throughout 1948 and 1949, there were many language movements. Meanwhile in Pakistan Constituent, Dhirendranath Dutta demanded the use of Bangla along with English and Urdu for conducting Assembly proceedings.

In 1949, The political leaders of East pakistan came out from the Muslim League and formed the Awami Muslim League in Rose Garden, Dhaka. The founding president of this political party was Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhashani. During the movements from 1948 - 1952, the Awami Muslim League and its student front, Chhatra League played an important role.

On 21 February of 1952, while there was a restriction of gathering by the Pakistan government, students ignored the restriction and demanded for Bangla as the state language in front of Dhaka Medical College. Police crossfired during the movement, killing many students including Salam, Barkat, Rafiq, Jabbar and others. When the news of student-killing spread across the country, the upset people from all over the country came out to participate in the movement. This movement went until Bangla was declared as the state language of Pakistan along with Urdu in the constituent in 1956.

The language movement was the first among the series of movements during the Pakistan period. This movement raised the sense of Bengali nationalism and accelerated the protest against Pakistanis. Because of this, the language movement is considered as the seed of Bengali nationalism and their path towards independence.

Assault on the Bengali Culture

Though Bangla was declared as a state language of Pakistan in 1956, the assault on Bengali culture continued. During the Ayub era, the idea of writing bangla in Roman script was propagated and the poems and songs of Rabindranath Tagore were considered against the values of Pakistan and the government stopped broadcasting those in the country in 1967. Bangla New Year celebration was also restricted.

During this time, *Chhayanaut* came forward to practice Rabindra songs and Rabindra-thoughts despite the restrictions.